Weight lifted, I ran rapidly through my priorities. I told Jimmy first, as we sat on the balcony watching the day's play. I had my sunglasses on as usual, pulled my cap down low and indulged my habit of chewing the collar of my sweatshirt. 'I'm really sorry I'm doing this to you now,' I said, behind a casually cupped hand, 'but I'm packing it in.' His face was a picture. 'I can't believe it,' he said. 'Are you sure? I'm sad – sad but shocked.'

Rooty was next on the list. I arranged to play nine holes with him on the golf course adjoining the Ageas Bowl in Southampton, before training began in earnest on the following Tuesday. I suspected, correctly, he had sussed out what was going on, but wanted to tell him face to face. I told Broady on the outfield the next morning; the secret was safe with all three.

Was there any need for the cloak-and-dagger stuff? Probably not, though I didn't want to be a distraction. Trevor Bayliss, the England coach, told me that, for the first time, the selectors were discussing my position. 'That's absolutely understandable,' I acknowledged. 'I haven't delivered a good stat this summer and have had a couple of big scores with not much in between for twelve months, but you don't have to worry. The next game will be my last, if I'm picked.'

He looked at me inscrutably: 'Oh, right. Thought that might happen …'

Trevor and Rooty led a happy dressing-room debrief immediately after we clinched the series by winning that Test, before handing over to me. I was a few beers in at that time, to quell the nerves, because I didn't know how I was going to react to telling the rest of the lads. I didn't go full Oscar acceptance speech, but my voice caught a couple of times.

The scene encapsulated what I will miss in the years to come. The deep satisfaction of the group, sharing the exclusivity of the moment. Job done, juices flowing, tension eased. 'This might be a sad day for some people or a happy day for others,' I announced, 'but I just want to let you know that my next Test, if picked, will be my last. I've run out of steam and this has been a great way to finish.'

Sportsmen take the piss at every opportunity, of course, so I didn't get away scot free. I had wanted to come across as thoughtful, despite the obvious intensity of emotion I felt, so ended with a light-hearted apology for dampening the mood. Moeen Ali, who has a dry sense of humour and a quick wit, shot back: 'Well, you just have, haven't you?' Not his best line, perhaps, but enough to crack everyone up.